

Elsie Dixon holds James Robert, born November 1923



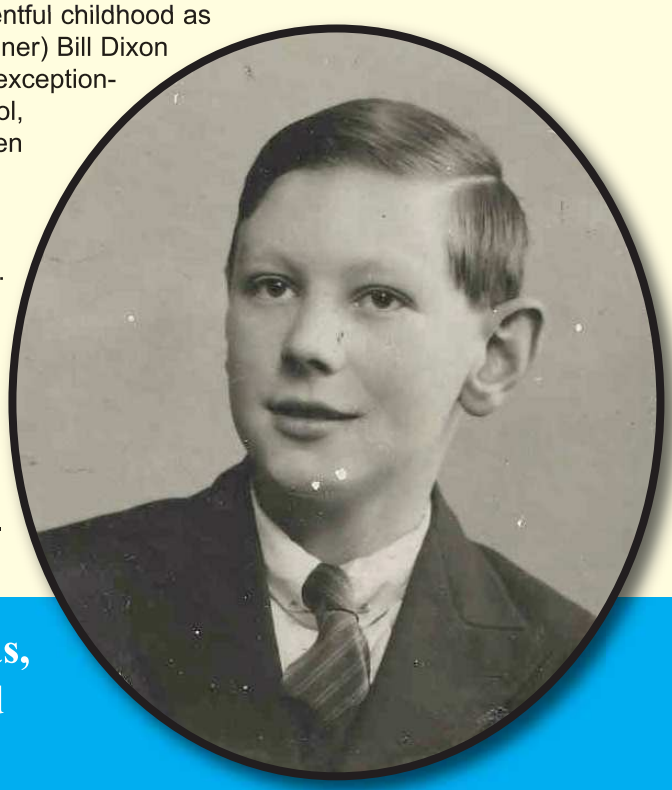
Jimmy shares a joke with Mum (Elsie) and Grandma (Margaret) at Clapham Station, Yorkshire, 1920s



Jim's had been a happy and uneventful childhood as the only child of tailor (formerly miner) Bill Dixon and his wife Elsie. He was doing exceptionally well at Rotherham Grammar School, Yorkshire, and his headmaster had been urging that he should go to university.

However, his photo at the top right - playing soldiers at a Territorial Army camp in 1932 - proved prophetic. He was never to be a student. War broke out when he was fifteen, and his German contemporaries were joining the Hitler Youth. (The recruitment poster on the right translates as: 'Youth serves the leader. All ten-year-olds into the Hitler Youth'.)

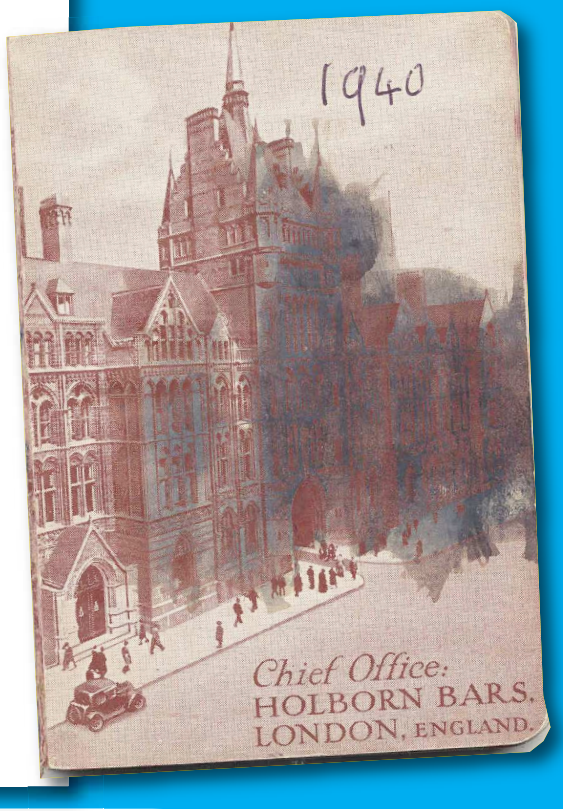
In 1942 - aged 18 - Jim eagerly volunteered for the British army.





"An excellent Christmas, despite Hitler and Lord Haw Haw!"

This was the opening of Jim's diary for January 1940. Jim was about to take his Higher School Certificate (like A-Levels) at the unusually early age of sixteen. Hopes of higher education put aside, he was looking for a job to tide him over until old enough to join the armed forces. His tiny diary (a freebie from Prudential Insurance) mixes war news with schoolboy preoccupations and domestic trivia in an often amusing way. (Mind you, I suppose a frozen outdoor lavatory wasn't trivial to a family nervous about Hitler!) I've used only a selection of his diary entries. **(Janet)**



January 2 1940
...Misadventure with sardine tin. Air battle in [illegible]. Losses 2 Wellingtons, 2 Messerschmidts.

January 4 1940
Went to see Goodbye Mr Chips at Regal. Very good. Thaw well in. Registered for meat.

January 8 1940
Rationing started.

January 15 1940
Height 5'8". Wt. 7 st. 12½ Gain in year 2 (inches).

“Heard at 8 that Germany had invaded Denmark...”

January 25 1940
Finished epilogue essay, 17 pages. Lavatory still frozen.

March 13 1940
Russo-Finnish peace signed. Terms unexpectedly harsh. Revision all day. Books shifted, wish I’d revised more!

March 16 1940
Heard at exchange of possible job. All of a flutter.

March 17 (Sun) 1940
Up very late. Enemy raid on Scapa Flow, 1 civilian killed, 1 wounded. Still all of a flutter.

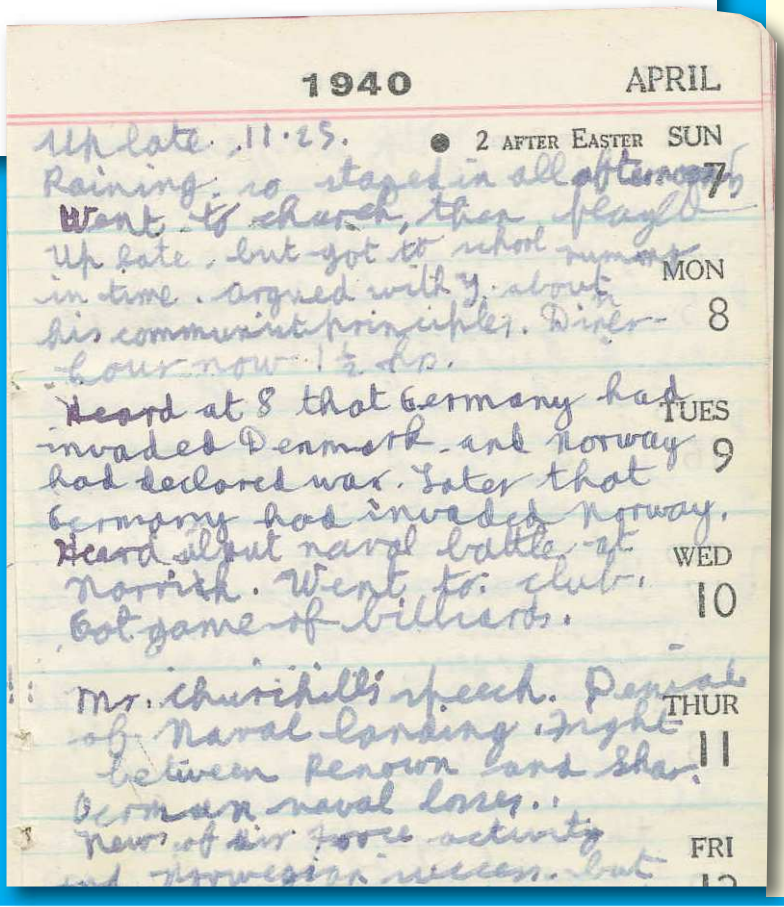
April 9 1940
Heard at 8 that Germany had invaded Denmark, and Norway had declared war.

April 12 1940
News of Air Force activity and Norwegian success – but nothing else. Why don’t we do something?

April 25 1940
Yorke and Moodycliffe broke open master’s desk and pinched books.

April 30 1940
Our table invaded by lower forms.

May 2 1940
Conducted blackboard war with Moodycliffe. No cricket, only net practice. Prime Minister’s announcement of withdrawal from [illegible].


1940 APRIL
Up late. 11.25. ● 2 AFTER EASTER SUN 7
Raining. no stayed in all afternoon
Went to church, then played
Up late, but got to school
in time. Argued with y. about
his communist principles. Diner-
hour now 1 to 2.
MON 8
Heard at 8 that Germany had
invaded Denmark and Norway
had declared war. Later that
Germany had invaded Norway.
TUES 9
Heard about naval battle of
Narvik. Went to club.
Got game of billiards.
WED 10
Mr. Churchill's speech. Repulse
of naval landing fight
between Renown and Scha-
German naval losses.
THUR 11
News of air force activity
and Norwegian success. but
FRI

Right: Jim’s father, Bill, in his Home Guard uniform.

(In summer 1940 the threat of invasion seemed so great that men outside fighting age were recruited into the Local Defence Volunteers, otherwise knows as Home Guard - or, more unkindly, ‘Dads Army’.)





Jim’s air raid shelter was probably an Anderson shelter like the one above (free to people who earned below 5 pounds a week). These consisted of corrugated iron sheets bolted together and half buried in the ground with earth heaped on top to protect them from bomb blasts. (Jim’s diary entry of **June 18** was: ‘Shovelled earth onto shelter with Wright’ - so presumably his school had an air raid shelter.)

People were said to have grown vegetables in the earth on top of the shelters. Hence this cartoon by Sidney Strove, Daily Express Nov 1940.

woman: “Is it all right now, Henry?” Man: “Yes, not even scratched.”





Children in school at gas mask drill, Alexander Macpherson, 1941 (Imperial War Museum)

Fall of France

It was rather ironic that Jim took the oral part of his Higher School Certificate French exam on June 14th - the day Paris was occupied by the Germans. He passed with distinction - but wouldn't get a French holiday any time soon. (Luckily he passed German too - which would prove useful in a few years when he was fighting abroad.)

Hitler's plan to invade Britain - Operation Sealion - required air superiority over Britain, so bombers attacked RAF bases, harbours, aircraft factories and infrastructure. Jim's town of Rotherham, Yorkshire, suffered bombing because it had industry, and was close to the major industrial city of Sheffield. In August 1940 his house lost a window to a bomb blast.

"Air raid warning at 1.15 AM. Got up, went to our shelter ¾ hour. ... Went to school in aft."

May 21 1940
Serious enemy advance to Amiens and Arras. Weather still fine. I can't throw a javelin.

May 24 1940
Holiday in afternoon for Empire Day. Stayed in and got headache. King's broadcast. Father went to Defence Force meeting.

June 4 1940
Weather still very good … Played cricket at dinner-time. Evacuation of 377,000 men from Dunkirk completed. Shirt-sleeves at school.

June 7 1940
Air raid warning at 1.15 AM. Got up, went to our shelter ¾ hr. Stayed in bed all morning. Went to school in aft. …'

June 8 1940
Air raid warning - same time, ¼ hr. Stayed in morning. To Granny and town. 3d on ice cream.

June 14 1940
Off to Sheffield for oral French exam. Just before start, blew nose. Buckets of blood. *Horreur!*

June 15 (Sat) 1940
Again up late. Bath before arriving. Then to Granny's. (Met her on street) … Yesterday, fall of Paris. *Hélas!* [Alas!]

June 18 1940
In gym during dinner hour. Shovelled earth onto shelter with Wright. France not yet surrendered. PM broadcast [see right].



"The Battle of France is over. I expect that the Battle of Britain is about to begin. Upon this battle depends the survival of Christian civilisation. ... The whole fury and might of the enemy must very soon be turned on us. Hitler knows that he will have to break us in this island or lose the war. If we can stand up to him, all Europe may be freed and the life of the world may move forward into broad, sunlit uplands.

But, if we fail, then the whole world, including the United States ... will sink into the abyss of a new dark age made more sinister ... by the lights of perverted science. Let us therefore brace ourselves to our duties, and so bear ourselves, that if the British Empire and its Commonwealth last for a thousand years, men will still say, this was their finest hour." **Winston Churchill, 18th June 1940**

June 24 1940
Weather a bit better. Difficult time transferring piano to prefects room. Damage to wall. France signs with Italy. Filling gradually disappearing.

June 26 (Wed) 1940
Raid 1.30 – 2.20, then 2.40 – 2.45. We find out how to black shelter out.

June 27 1940
Dreamed of sirens all night, but none! Rumania cedes Bessarabia. … Wright threw books into C's classroom!

July 1 1940
… Exam started 9.15 … Paper 1 easy. Paper 2 fairly stiff. Walked home with Mother.

July 11 1940
Up fairly late. In aft. went to library. Met Beavis. Then home with 'I Claudius'. Read it all night – headache. 23 German [bombs?]

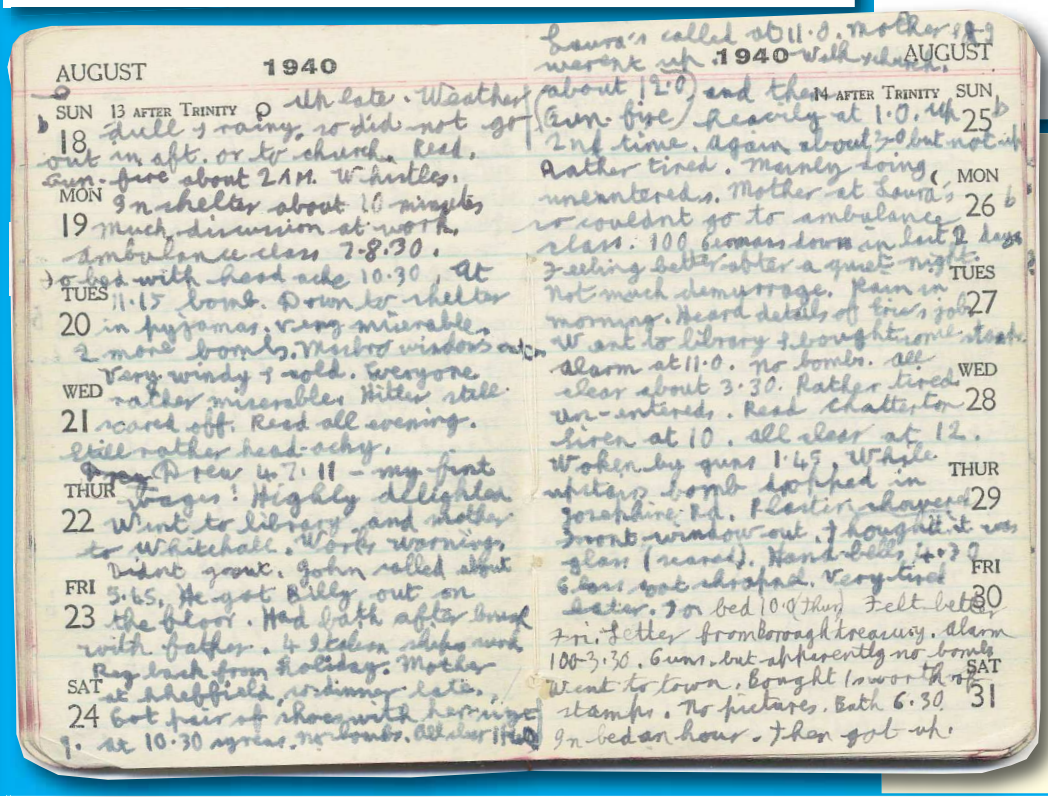
July 12 1940
Tried to get Meccano [next word unreadable] span to work.

"...at 11.15 bomb. Down to shelter... Very miserable. 2 more bombs. ..."

July 13 1940
… Father came home in L.D.V. [Local Defence Volunteers] uniform.

July 14 1940
… Measured for suit. Rally in aft. in Clifton Park. Father there with rifle. Mother and I as well.

July 15 1940
Did no work at all. Bored. Must get a job.


AUGUST 1940

SUN 18 13 AFTER TRINITY
MON 19
TUES 20
WED 21
THUR 22
FRI 23
SAT 24

AUGUST 1940

SUN 25 14 AFTER TRINITY
MON 26
TUES 27
WED 28
THUR 29
FRI 30
SAT 31

July 22 1940
Spent all day in library, chess and reading. Beautiful! No invasion yet!

July 26 1940
Off to Sheffield for railway interview.

Aug 2 1940
Letter from railway. I start Tuesday.

Aug 12 1940
Work again. Carting dusty old books. More and more enemy planes down. In evening went to ambulance class.

Aug 17 (Sat) 1940
Work in morning. Learnt I had passed HSC with Distinction in French.

Aug 19 1940
Gun-fire about 2 AM. Whistles [raid warning]. In shelter about 10 minutes. Much discussion at work. Ambulance class 7 - 8.30.

Aug 20 1940
… at 11.15 bomb. Down to shelter in pyjamas. Very miserable. 2 more bombs. Masboro windows out.

Aug 21 1940
Very windy and cold. Everyone rather miserable. Hitler still scared off.

Aug 22 1940
Drew 47.11 – my first wages! [less than £2.50!]

Aug 29 1940
Woken by guns at 1.45. While upstairs, bomb dropped in Josephine Rd. Plaster showered. Front window out. Thought it was glass (scared). Hand-bells 4.30. Glass soot [?] shrapnel ...
[Hand-bells were an 'all clear' sign]

Rotherham raids

Jim's town of Rotherham received only two serious raids, according to my information source. The first, on the night of August 19, was aimed at the Templeborough Steel Works, but two people were killed when it hit the wrong factory.

The second raid on 29 August caused extensive damage in the Holmes area, with windows blown out all over town.These raids are mentioned in Jim's diaries. The entry for August 29 is badly written, but it sounds as though a bomb fell on Josephine Road - next to his own street of Ferham Road - and the blast blew out the Dixons' window.



Cartoon by Illingworth

Battle of Britain

The Battle of Britain commenced in full in mid-August, when the Luftwaffe attacked airfields and radar stations.

Britain, whose planes were greatly outnumbered by the Luftwaffe's, was suffering from heavy losses and exhausted pilots.

On September 4, Hitler ordered the bombing of British cities and towns. Strikes against London - the Blitz - began on September 7 and continued until May 1941, with the aim of destroying civilian morale.

This change of tactics to civilian targets reduced pressure on RAF airfields, and gave them time to recover their losses.The RAF began inflicting heavy casualties on the attacking Germans. Following the decisive defeat of waves of bombers on September 15, Hitler postponed his invasion plan.



Quote from Churchill speech, August 20 1940

Sept 3 1940
Anniversary of declaration of war.

Sept 9/10 1940
Went to ambulance class. Practised with splints. Sirens 10 – 11.10. To bed 1.30. Up at 8 again … 306 killed on Sunday. … (I haven't had time to clean teeth for 2 days.)

Sept (Fri) 13 1940
… Heard I was to be in delivery office 5.30 AM. Horrified … Buckingham Palace bombed.

Oct 11 1940
Cherbourg bombarded, and the RAF gave 'em a good pounding.

Dec 12/13 1940
Continuous gunfire until 3 AM. Woke in shelter 4.15 AM! Denzil had been putting out incendiaries. Sheffield badly bombed. Shrapnel in yard. Trains, vans and staff late.

Dec 31 1940
Proud to have kept my diary for a year!



Injured survivors of the blast are comforted. (The picture appeared in a newspaper of the time, and now features in a BBC site.)

Sheffield's tragic raids

At least 70 people were killed by a single bomb that destroyed the 7-storey Marples hotel, Sheffield, on the night of **12/13 December 1940.**

Many were sheltering its extensive network of cellars. Some were guests, others had sought safety from the fires started by incendiary bombs in the surrounding streets.

Miraculously, the roof of the bottle-cellar held, and 7 men inside escaped serious injury. They were rescued the next day.

Sheffield was bombed (in Operation Crucible) because of its manufacture of munitions and aircraft parts. It suffered two major raids in December, resulting in some 600 fatalities.





Left: King George VI and Queen Elizabeth inspect bomb damage to Buckingham Palace. Above: ruins of Marples Hotel, Sheffield.

Dashed dreams in a bombed Britain

Found among Jim's papers was a letter of recommendation from his headmaster - as clean as the day it was typed on October 12 1940, being read but still in its original envelope.

The headmaster was plainly bitter that the school prodigy was apparently throwing himself away on a lowly clerical job.

Could Jim have gone on to higher education at that time? Presumably he'd have liked to, as the diaries show his love of books and study. But he appears to have felt it wasn't practical. Even if he could have got a scholarship, these were unstable times when academic ambitions often had to be put on hold.

German invasion was a possibility. Even Buckingham Palace was bomb-damaged (as Jim's diary noted). The Marples Hotel in neighbouring Sheffield was still standing when this letter was written - two months later it was a heap of rubble.

Jim seems to have decided to take an office job to tide him over and join the army as soon as old enough.He continued his education with evening classes in shorthand, arithmetic and English. He never did go to university, though. When finally released from the army he was well into his twenties, and keen to join the civil service, where he enjoyed a successful career.

County Borough of Rotherham

GRAMMAR SCHOOL

FOUNDED 1483

F. W. FIELD, M.A.
HEAD MASTER

TEL. 601 ROTHERHAM

Rotherham.

12th October, 1940.

J. R. Dixon attended this School from 1934 until July of this year. He is a boy of excellent character and conduct and possesses an unusually good brain.

In 1938 he obtained his School Certificate and in 1940 at the age of 16 years 8 months his Higher School Certificate with a distinction in French, an outstanding performance.

He could undoubtedly have had a brilliant academic career but as such a course held no attraction to him he left us to take clerical employment. I have no doubts as to his ability to get on as he possesses a strong fund of common sense allied to a streak of obstinacy, a combination which helps him to know his own mind and carry out his intentions.

(Signed), F.W. Field.
Headmaster.

Rotherham Grammar School

ROTHERHAM 5.30PM 14 OCT 1940 YORKSHIRE

POSTAGE REVENUE 2½d

J. R. Dixon.

83 Ferham Rd.

1941

Jim, now turned 17, joined the Home Guard on February 10. (His Home Guard experiences are in a separate section.) But he had other preoccupations: first alcoholic drink; first dance (at the Carlton Danse Salon, Rotherham, billed as 'The Most Ideal Rendezvous' in a newspaper cutting Jim kept); and trying to get a first date!

"Plucked up courage to *demander a Selene*"

March 14 1941
Ted got his preliminary call-up papers ... Sirens and guns, so slept behind sofa.

April 1 1941
J'ai suggéré à 'E' qu'elle m'accompagnerait au kino. Probablement oui … [I asked 'E' to come to the cinema with me - probably yes]

April 2 1941
Elle répond qu'elle part trop tard (peu d'enthousiasme).
[she replied that she leaves too late - little enthusiasm.]

May 13 1941
Hear Rudolf Hess had landed in Scotland. What a sensation!

August 9 1941
To work in boots and bayonet. Quite the centre of attention.

Nov 3 1941
Propose fragen Selene au kino gehen... [I am going to ask Selene to the cinema...]

Nov 5 1941
Plucked up courage to *demander a Selene.* Indecisive result.

Nov 6 1941
… For my eighteenth birthday I had torch battery from Mother (by request) and 5s from Dad – chocolates from Grandma.

Nov 12 1941
Mr Bellamy and Mr Congden chaffed me heavily, *'E' and Sel ayant révélé ce que je leur ai demandé.* ['E' and Sel having revealed what I asked them.]
… Fine supper, sausage and mash.

Nov 13 1941
Father irascible, but not as bad as sometimes. America revised neutrality Act.



A British wartime dance (picture from Imperial War Museum)

The Pepys influence

Jim was a great enthusiast for the published diaries of Samuel Pepys, a British naval administrator who recorded the years 1660 to 1669. Jim copied his frustrating habit of recording romantic affairs in a cocktail of foreign languages - which I have struggled to translate. He was also inclined to end his diary entries in Pepys style, with lines like 'and so to supper and to bed' - even when bed was a trench!



Nov 17 1941
After tea I went to the Carlton for my 1st dancing lesson. I was shown the Quickstep, Empress Tango and Waltz. Enjoyed myself fine.

Dec 8 1941
Japan declares war on Britain, USA and vice versa.

Dec 12 1941
… Am reading poems of GK Chesterton. Have got cigars for Father, dress front for Grandma. …

Dec 20 1941
…Went to town and chose gift from Mother (Pepys diary).

Dec 24 1941
All the blighters seem to have gone home early, except Denzil and me! Went to town to buy map, found I needed permit, so got one from police stn.

Dec 30 1941
Took trifles up to H.G. [Home Guard] 7.30.Father furious because cream spilled. Fine supper. 3 glass beer and 1 jug….

Dec 31 1941
…Strangely enough, I felt no ill effects or hangover. …